The Conflict Story

Which of your two is stronger, the clash you need to solve first, and the move in story one that you described in half a sentence and is the best thing in either.

Doc 51 · "Tell us about a time you resolved a conflict" · Asset Management, Client Solutions Group · Prepared 5 November 2026

1 Which is stronger

	STORY 1 · the slide deck	STORY 2 · the other intern
Who you disagreed with	**Your manager.** Real power asymmetry, real risk to you.	A peer. Socially easier, lower stakes.
What was at stake	Client-facing material going to the sales team and clients.	Project direction. Needs establishing — currently vague.
How you resolved it	**Evidence plus a reframed alternative.** See section 3 — this is the strong part.	A private meeting and an honest comparison. Good, and underplayed.
The result	He preferred your version, and admitted a gap of his own.	"We were praised." Vague — needs fixing.
Risk of sounding arrogant	Moderate — manageable with the framing in section 5.	Higher, because "she saw I was right" is how it currently lands.

Story 1 is clearly stronger. Disagreeing upward is harder and more revealing than disagreeing with a peer, the stakes are real, and your actual resolution move is more sophisticated than you realise.

2 But solve this first: it collides with your weakness answer

THE PROBLEM

Your weakness answer (doc 41) is *"I've been slow to push back on people more senior than me"* — evidenced by **the same slide deck incident.**

If both questions come up and you tell that story twice, the reviewer hears one anecdote doing two jobs. That reads as thin experience, which is precisely what neither answer can afford.

The decision rule for the day

Do not try to be clever about this under pressure. One rule, applied mechanically:

WHICHEVER QUESTION COMES FIRST GETS THE SLIDE DECK IN FULL

If "conflict" comes first → slide deck, told in full as below. Then if weakness comes later, use a *different* weakness entirely — "wanting to be certain before I'll say anything" from the menu I gave you — so there is no overlap at all.

If "weakness" comes first → slide deck, told as the weakness. Then if conflict comes later, use **story 2**, which is why it is worth preparing properly rather than discarding.

ONE THING ONLY YOU CAN SETTLE

Were the "the deck wasn't client-ready" conversation and the "photo on the slide" disagreement **the same conversation, or two separate moments on the same project?**

If genuinely separate, you have two usable incidents and the clash mostly disappears. If they were one conversation, the rule above applies strictly. **Be honest with yourself about this** — splitting one conversation into two stories is the sort of thing that unravels at a Superday.

3 Story 1: the move you described in half a sentence

You said: *"I also gave like an alternative. I said, look, if you want that, how about adding a small circle of the person's face just so they get the recognition."*

That is the best thing in either story and you threw it away. Here is what you actually did:

YOU SEPARATED WHAT HE WANTED FROM WHAT HE ASKED FOR

Your manager's **stated position** was: put a photo of the person on the slide.

His **underlying interest** was: the person who closed the deal gets recognised.

Those are not the same thing — and almost everyone argues about the first while ignoring the second. **You found a way to satisfy the interest without the position**: a small circle that gives the recognition without compromising the design.

That is textbook interest-based negotiation, and you did it instinctively. **It is also the reason the conflict resolved rather than one of you simply losing.**

Two other things you are underselling

1. YOU BROUGHT EVIDENCE INSTEAD OF TASTE

"None of our competitors present their slides this way" converts *"I think it looks bad"* into *"here's what the market does."*

That distinction matters enormously when you are the junior person. **Taste loses to seniority. Evidence does not.** And you were not manufacturing a case — you already had the competitive research from earlier work, which is worth saying because it shows the research had a second use.

2. THE REAL RESULT IS NOT THAT YOU WON

You said he told you he *"didn't have the design eye for making it client-worthy."*

Stop and notice what that is. **A manager volunteering something he is not good at, to an intern.** People only do that when a disagreement has been handled in a way that did not make them defensive.

So the outcome is not "he agreed with me" — it is "he felt able to say what he wasn't good at." That is a much better result and a much better thing to report, because it says something about how you raised it rather than about who was right.

4 Story 1: the full answer

About 105 seconds. STAR-R, with the reflection doing real work.

SITUATION — ~20 SECONDS

So this was on my placement at Pictet. I was working on redesigning the slide decks the sales team used — we were building them from scratch rather than off the corporate template, and they were going to be used with clients. And I had a disagreement with my manager about one of the design decisions, which as an intern was quite uncomfortable.

TASK — ~15 SECONDS

He wanted a photo of the person who'd closed the deal on the slide. I thought that made it look less like client-facing material, and the other analyst I was working with agreed. But he's considerably senior to me and it was his call, so the question was really whether to say anything at all.

ACTION — ~40 SECONDS

The first thing I decided was that I wasn't going to make it about taste, because I'd lose that and I'd deserve to. I'd done some competitive research earlier in the placement, so I went back to it — and none of the firms we'd looked at presented their client material that way. So I could put it as what the market does rather than what I think looks good.

But the thing I'd actually point to is that I tried to work out what he wanted it for, rather than just arguing against the photo. And what he wanted was for the person who'd closed the deal to get the recognition — which isn't really the same thing as a photo on a client slide. So I suggested a small circle with their face instead, so they'd still get the credit without it changing what the deck was.

RESULT — ~12 SECONDS

He went with it. [And one concrete outcome — how many decks, whether the sales team adopted the format.] And the bit I didn't expect was that he said he didn't really have the design eye for making things client-ready, which I thought was quite a generous thing to say to an intern.

REFLECTION — ~20 SECONDS

What I took from it is that most disagreements aren't actually about the thing being argued over. He asked for a photo; what he wanted was for someone to get credit. Once I'd separated those two, there was a version that gave him what he was after without the bit I disagreed with — and it stopped being a disagreement.

And the fact he then volunteered something he wasn't good at tells me it landed the right way. People don't do that if they've been made to feel defensive.

5 What to cut from story 1

Cut	Because
"It looked horrible"	Criticises your manager's judgement. Say what it did to the *reader* — "it made it look less like client-facing material."
Anything that frames it as you being right	The answer is about how you handled it, not about whose taste was better. "He went with it" is enough; do not dwell.
"Me and the other analyst both thought"	Mild safety-in-numbers. Own it yourself — and credit the other analyst separately if they did something.
Over-dramatising the conflict	It was a design disagreement, not a crisis. Calling it "quite uncomfortable" is honest; calling it a confrontation is not.
Naming your manager, or their title precisely	Unnecessary, and discretion is noticed.

THE ONE THING TO FIND TONIGHT

A concrete outcome. How many decks were redesigned? Did the sales team actually adopt the new format? Was it still in use when you left? Any of those turns "he went with it" into a result. Ten minutes in your emails or handover notes.

6 Story 2: also better than you are telling it

You need this one prepared regardless, because of the clash. And there are two things in it you have buried.

1 · YOU MADE A LIST OF PROS AND CONS FOR BOTH APPROACHES — INCLUDING HERS

Think about what that does. If you turn up with arguments for *your* position, it is a debate and somebody loses. **If you turn up with an honest comparison that includes the case against yourself, you have changed the activity from persuading to deciding.**

Which means she did not concede. **She evaluated.** And that is why it stuck — and why you got a better answer rather than just your answer.

You described this in one clause. It is the whole story.

2 · YOU TOOK IT PRIVATE, AND THAT WAS A REAL CHOICE

You messaged her directly and asked for a conversation in person, rather than raising it in front of others.

The textbook answer is "transparent communication with the team." The honest answer is that raising it in a group would have been worse — because in front of other people she would have had to defend her position, and people defend things in public that they would happily reconsider in private.

That is a pragmatic trade-off you can actually defend, which is exactly what the framework asks for.

Story 2: the full answer

ABOUT 95 SECONDS

Situation. On my placement I was working on a project with another intern, [say what the project was and what hung on it]. We disagreed about the direction it should take — she had a clear view and I had a different one, and we were both fairly convinced.

Task. And the thing I was conscious of is that I didn't want it to become a thing between us. We had to keep working together, and I wasn't trying to win — I just thought the other approach would produce a better result.

Action. So the first decision was where to have the conversation. I messaged her directly and asked if we could sit down rather than raising it with the wider group — because in front of other people she'd have had to defend her position, and people defend things publicly that they'd happily reconsider one to one.

And then rather than preparing an argument, I went away and wrote out the pros and cons of both approaches, including hers. Honestly — not a straw man. Which changed what the meeting was. It stopped being my opinion against hers and became the two of us looking at the same comparison.

Result. She looked at it and said she could see the case, and we went with the other approach. [And the concrete outcome — who praised it, for what.]

Reflection. What I took from it is that a lot of disagreements between people who want the same outcome aren't really disagreements — they're just two people working from different information. So the quickest way through is usually to stop arguing and go and build the comparison. And the honest trade-off is that taking it offline wasn't the most transparent thing to do — but it was the version where she could change her mind without it costing her anything.

7 Weak versus strong, on the same facts

HOW YOU'RE CURRENTLY TELLING STORY 1

"My manager wanted a photo of the person who closed the deal on the slide, but I thought it was better without. As an intern it's nerve-wracking but I realised sharing my opinion is crucial."

"I showed him the competitive research and said none of our competitors do it that way. I also gave an alternative with a small circle of their face."

"He appreciated the feedback and preferred my suggestion."

Problem: the best move is one clause, the result sounds like a win, and there is no reflection.

THE SAME FACTS, PROPERLY

"I decided not to make it about taste, because I'd lose that and I'd deserve to."

"But the thing I'd point to is that I tried to work out what he wanted it *for*. He asked for a photo; what he wanted was the person getting credit — which isn't the same thing."

"So there was a version that gave him what he was after without the bit I disagreed with, and it stopped being a disagreement."

"And he then volunteered something he wasn't good at, which tells me it landed the right way."

What changed	Why it scores
The negotiation move is foregrounded	Separating the position from the interest is the sophisticated bit. It was a clause; now it is the answer.
"I'd lose that and I'd deserve to"	Self-aware about your own standing without being servile. Shows you understood the dynamic you were in.
The result is about him, not you	"He felt able to say what he wasn't good at" is evidence about *your handling*. "He agreed with me" is just an outcome.
A real reflection	"Most disagreements aren't about the thing being argued over" is transferable, non-obvious, and earned from the story.

8 Follow-ups

They ask	You say
"What if he'd said no?"	The best question and you should have it ready. "Then it was his call and I'd have built what he asked for. *I'd said my piece with evidence and offered an alternative — at that point continuing to push would have been about me rather than the deck.*"
"Was it really a conflict?"	Do not inflate it. "It was a disagreement rather than a row. But it was with someone considerably senior about something going to clients, so it mattered more than the subject suggests."
"Were you right?"	Stay light. "He preferred the version we ended up with. I'd be wary of claiming much more than that about a design decision."
"How did you know he'd take it well?"	Honest. "I didn't. That's why I went with evidence and an alternative rather than just an objection — it gave him somewhere to go other than yes or no."
"Tell me about another one."	Story 2. Which is why it is worth having prepared.

> **THE THREE SENTENCES THAT CARRY STORY 1**
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> **1.** "I decided not to make it about taste, because I'd lose that and I'd deserve to."
> **2.** "He asked for a photo; what he wanted was for someone to get credit. Those aren't the same thing."
> **3.** "He then volunteered something he wasn't good at, which tells me it landed the right way."
>
> Land those three and the answer is well clear of a field that mostly describes having a polite conversation.

What is mine and what is yours. Both stories are entirely yours — the deck redesign, the photo disagreement, the competitive research, the small-circle alternative, your manager's remark about the design eye, and with the other intern the private message, the in-person meeting and the two-sided list. What I have added is the framing: that you separated a stated position from an underlying interest, that evidence beats taste when you are the junior party, that the manager volunteering a gap of his own is the real result, and that an honest comparison including the case against yourself converts persuading into deciding. Everything in square brackets is yours to supply and should not be said unless true. The question of whether the two slide-deck conversations were one moment or two is one only you can answer, and it matters — a Superday interviewer from that team would know.